

Language as a tool



By the mid-20th century, analytic philosophy had become the predominant philosophy of the English-speaking world. Logical positivism was also influential, as members of the Vienna Circle fled from Nazism to Britain and the United States, and its strict criteria of meaningfulness were applied to all forms of language, not just science. Analytic philosophy had become largely an analysis of language, rather than of philosophical questions. But not all British philosophers accepted this trend, and some, such as G.E. Moore, argued for a 'common sense' approach to logical analysis of language. Wittgenstein also returned to the argument, realizing that his

Tractatus was self-contradictory: it was full of propositions that do not picture the world, and so are meaningless. In its place, he developed an entirely different linguistic philosophy, dropping the metaphor of language 'picturing' reality and replacing it with language as a tool. Each word or concept does not mean a specific thing, but derives its meaning from the intention of its user and the context in which it is used.